



2 OCTOBER 2026

WESTPAC—DATA CARD TRACKER

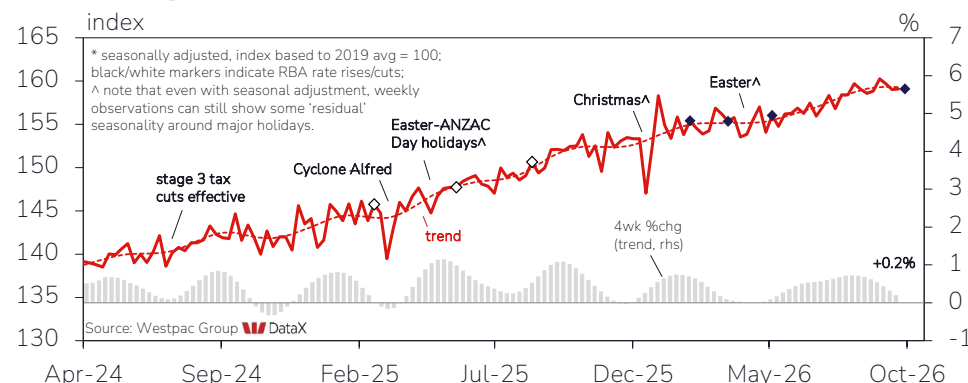
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Card activity: soft finish to a strong quarter

- The **Westpac–DataX Card Tracker Index*** has edged up slightly since late August, rising 0.2pts to 159.1.
- Quarterly growth momentum has seen a further lift and is now tracking towards a 1.7% gain for the September quarter which would mark the strongest quarterly rise since June 2025.
- However, both the monthly and weekly reads show momentum has faded over the course of the quarter. After posting 0.7-0.9%^{mth} gains through May, June and July, the Index rose just 0.2% in August and is tracking a similarly subdued 0.3% pace for September. Weekly reads are also tracking a more moderate trend pace of 0.2%^{mth}.
- On a quarterly basis, the detail shows discretionary services and international transactions have led the pick-up. While some of this looks to be catch-up from travel disruptions in the June quarter, gains have been consistent and broadly based. Likewise, there is little evidence that the pick-up is coming from a lift in prices with recent CPI updates suggesting services inflation has been steady rather than accelerating (see [here](#)).
- On the apparent loss of momentum over the course of the quarter, the detail suggests this is a re-run of the fuel price squeeze in March-April-May with the essentials spend gain rising strongly. So far the spillover effects are showing up mainly as a dampening in discretionary goods spend with the slowing in discretionary services largely confined to hospitality.
- Overall, the card tracker data suggests the Q3 spending data will still come in as a relatively solid gain, even allowing for a firmer gain in prices in the quarter. However, the fade in momentum is notable with the impact of further fuel price increases and this week's RBA rate rise still to come. Add what now looks more likely to be a follow-on interest rate hike in November and the December quarter is shaping as a significant slowdown in card activity.

“... both the monthly and weekly reads show momentum has faded over the course of the quarter.”

1. Westpac–DataX Card Tracker Index*



The **Westpac–DataX Card Tracker** presents indicators based on the millions of credit and debit card transactions processed by Westpac every day. The measures are a timely guide to shifts in spending. See p9 for a detailed explanation.

This report is produced by Westpac Economics.

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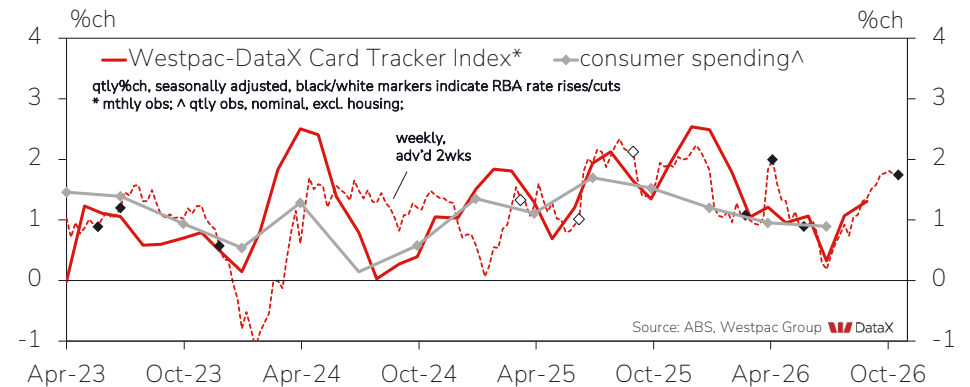
Card activity points to ~0.7%qtr gain in Q3 in real, inflation adjusted terms

- Chart 2 shows how quarterly growth in the **Westpac-DataX Card Tracker Index** compares to growth in nominal consumption as reported in the quarterly national accounts. All estimates are adjusted for regular seasonal variations. Quarterly growth momentum is now tracking around 1.7%, the strongest pace since the fuel price spike in March, and prior to that, since the turn of the year.
- Notably, growth ex fuel has slowed since the start of September, tracking a slower 1.4% quarterly pace in the latest week. This reflects both the end of the temporary halving in fuel excise tax and the latest resurgence in energy prices globally.
- Recall that Q2 national accounts showed nominal spending (excluding housing costs, which are not covered in our card tracker indicators) rose 0.9%qtr, similar to Q1's 1%qtr gain but with annual growth slowing to 4.7%yr from 5.5%yr. Growth in real, inflation-adjusted terms was more subdued at +0.4%qtr, 1.8%yr (near flat in per capita terms). The detail was 'messy' with significant disruptions from the Middle East conflict (see [here](#)).
- The card tracker data now has 12 of the 13 weeks of Q3. As such, the 1.7%qtr rise in nominal terms and price rise in the 1%qtr range points to a real, inflation adjusted gain of around 0.7%qtr, in line with Westpac's current forecasts.

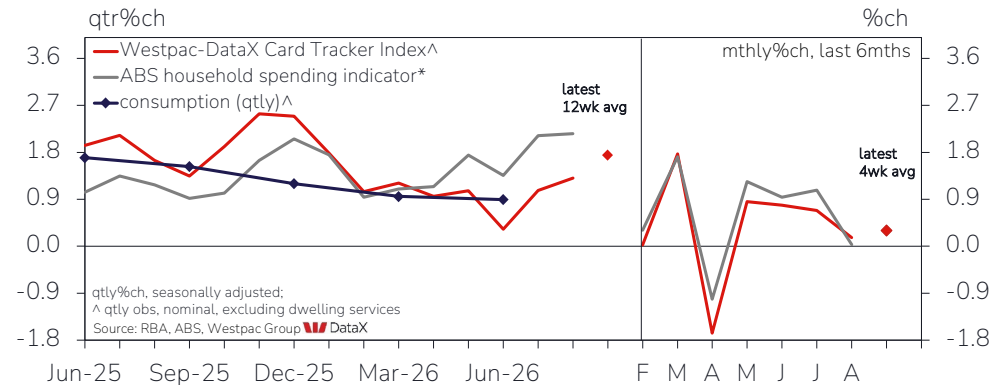
qtrly%ch	Q4	Q1	Q2	latest [^]
Westpac-DataX Card Tracker	2.5	1.2	0.3	1.7
ABS monthly household spending indicator*				
Nominal	2.1	1.1	1.4	2.2
Real*	0.9	0.8	0.7	n.a.
ABS consumer spending (qtrly)#				
Nominal	1.2	1.0	0.9	n.a.
Real	0.5	0.4	0.4	n.a.

All series seasonally adjusted. Latest is either the latest weekly obs (12wks %ch on previous 12wks) or latest monthly obs (3mths %ch on previous 3mths). See p9 for more details.
 * ABS monthly household spending indicator based on domestic card transaction and new vehicle sales data. Real estimates are quarterly.
 # Consumer spending excludes housing costs.
 Sources: ABS, Westpac Group

2. Card activity and spending: growth momentum



3. Consumer spending: selected indicators



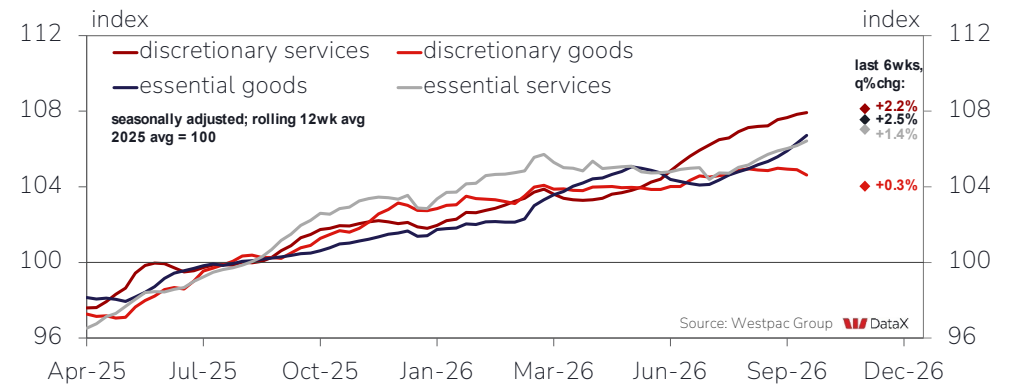
Fuel spend rises, discretionary momentum fades

- Chart 4 shows quarterly growth in card activity across broad categories. The year has been marked by rotations between essentials and discretionary categories as fuel price shocks have washed in and out. The switch from essentials to discretionary categories – services in particular – in the early part of Q3 is again reversing with the main drag coming in discretionary goods.
- In quarterly growth terms, essential goods is now leading, running at 2.5%qtr, with discretionary services still relatively strong at 2.2%qtr, essential services tracking more slowly at 1.4%qtr and discretionary goods much weaker at just 0.3%qtr (flat to down in per capita terms).
- Digging into the more detailed discretionary services segments, the initial quarterly pickup came from a big turnaround in transport services, which look to be partly a rebound from air travel disruptions in Q2 with a similar pattern evident in ‘international transactions’ (which are not included in discretionary services category, as they include some goods purchases, but are presented here as corroborating evidence). The charts on p6-7 provide some more detail on the other categories. Notably the weakening in discretionary goods momentum looks to be broad-based.
- Regionally, the softening is a little more evident in Vic than in other states.

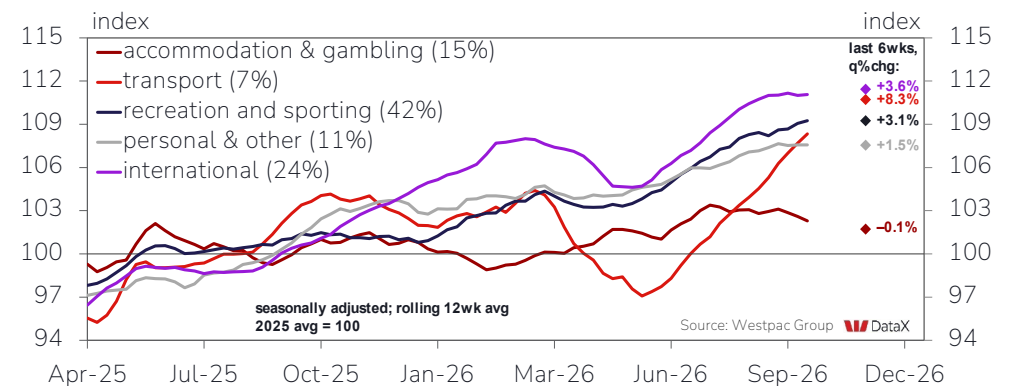
	Jun	Jul	Aug	26/9
Westpac–DataX Card Tracker	157.0	158.1	158.4	159.1
By category				
– discretionary*	159.2	160.4	159.9	159.7
– essential*	151.6	152.7	153.6	156.6
By state				
– NSW	149.8	151.2	151.0	154.4
– Vic	147.7	148.9	149.7	151.1
– Qld	171.8	174.1	172.6	174.8
– WA	173.9	175.7	176.7	178.6
– SA	163.6	165.0	166.3	166.3

All indexes based on the value of spending-related transactions, seasonally adjusted, 2019 avg=100, see p9 for more details including classifications.
 * indexes revised due to re-classification.
 Sources: ABS, Westpac Group

4. Card activity by broad category



5. Card activity: discretionary services & international

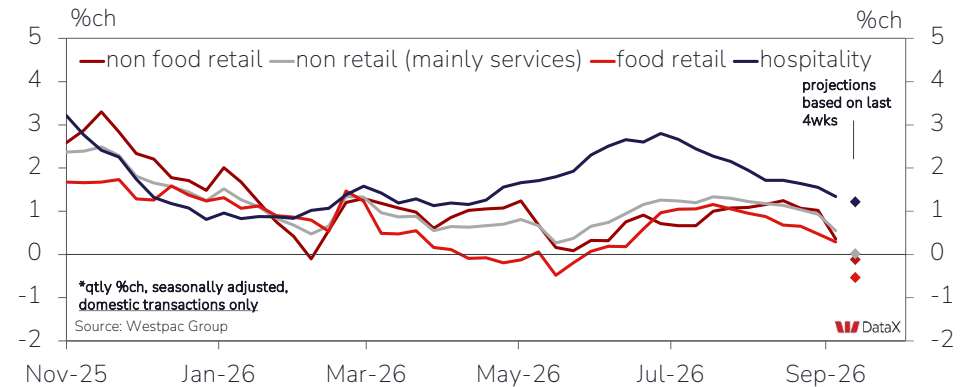


Retail retreats

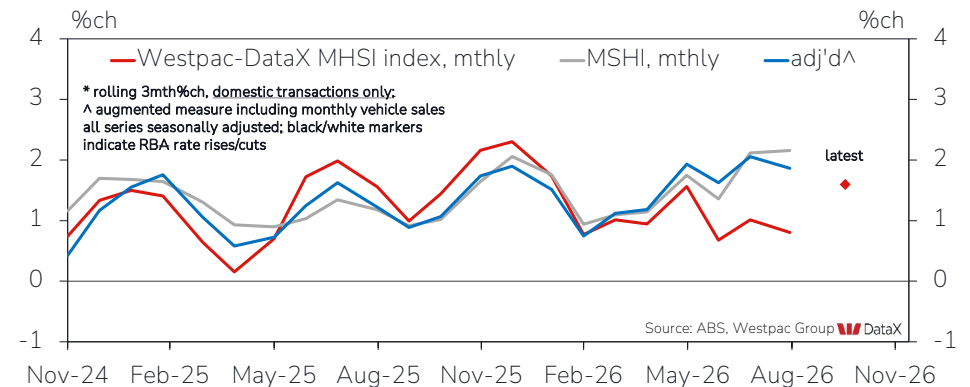
- Our MHSI and retail card indexes are composite measures based on transactions in categories that are in scope for the ABS monthly household spending indicator (MHSI) and retail sales estimates (which have been based on the MHSI detail since the ABS retail survey was discontinued in June 2025).
- As noted previously, the retail and MHSI index measures significantly outperformed the broader WCTI in Q2 but with the gap narrowing in July-August. The latest weekly signals now show both more in line at 1.6%qtr and 1.7%qtr respectively.
- The retail card index measure is a narrower subset of spend that excludes fuel and most services except hospitality. Chart 6 shows a sharp weakening in non food retail in recent weeks with food retail also stalling but hospitality tracking a firmer, albeit slowing pace.
- The ABS MHSI was a little firmer than we expected but came in below market expectations in August with a flat result, the 3mth growth rate ticking up to 2.2%qtr. Note that a significant part of the quarterly strength is coming from vehicle sales which surged through the middle of the year (see [here](#) for more).

	Jun	Jul	Aug	26/9
MHSI card index	153.7	155.1	155.2	157.3
– qtly%ch	0.7	1.0	0.8	1.6
– qtly, ann%ch	5.1	5.2	5.4	5.3
ABS MHSI				
– %ch	0.9	1.1	0.0	n.a.
– qtly%ch	1.4	2.1	2.2	n.a.
– qtly ann%ch	5.5	5.3	5.5	n.a.
Retail card index	154.6	155.6	155.2	154.2
– qtly%ch	1.1	1.8	1.3	0.5
– qtly, ann%ch	5.3	5.6	5.3	4.6
ABS retail sales				
– %ch	0.2	1.0	-0.2	n.a.
– qtly%ch	1.4	1.8	1.5	n.a.
– qtly ann%ch	5.2	5.5	5.6	n.a.

6. Card activity: retail segments and non-retail

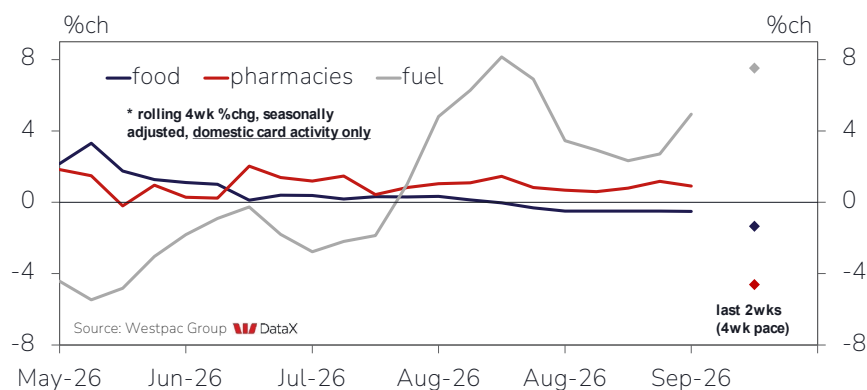


7. Card activity: ABS MHSI index vs WCTI measures

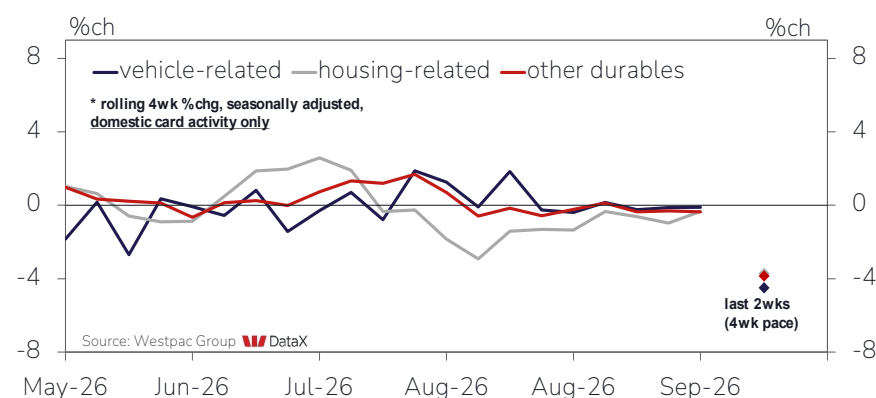


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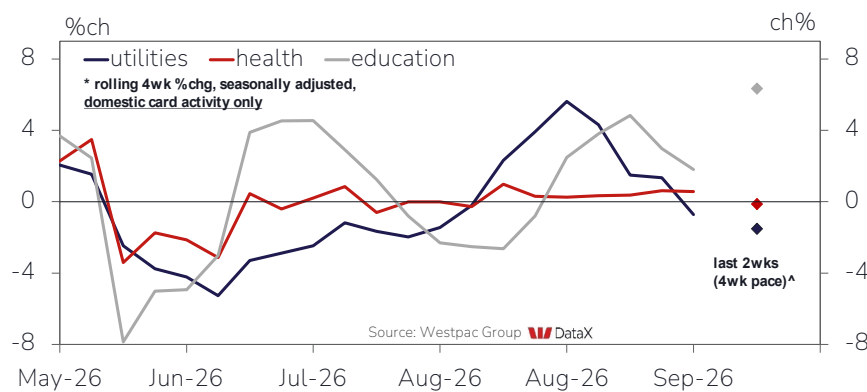
8. Card activity: essential goods



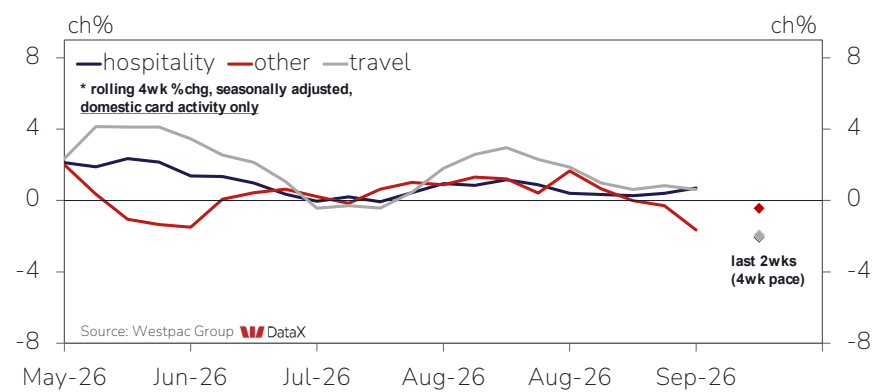
9. Card activity: discretionary goods



10. Card activity: essential services

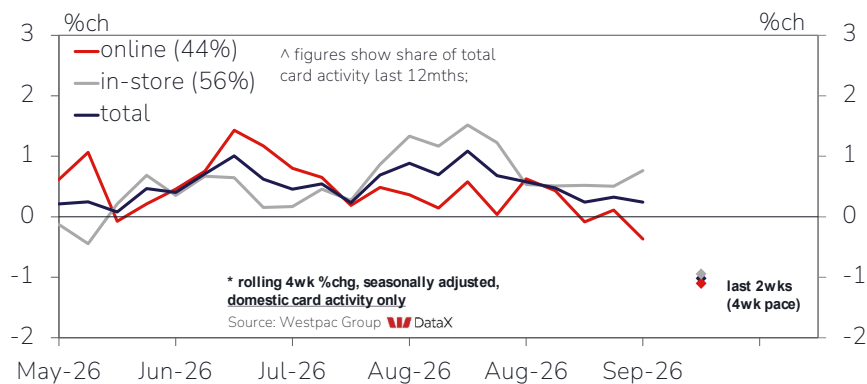


11. Card activity: discretionary services

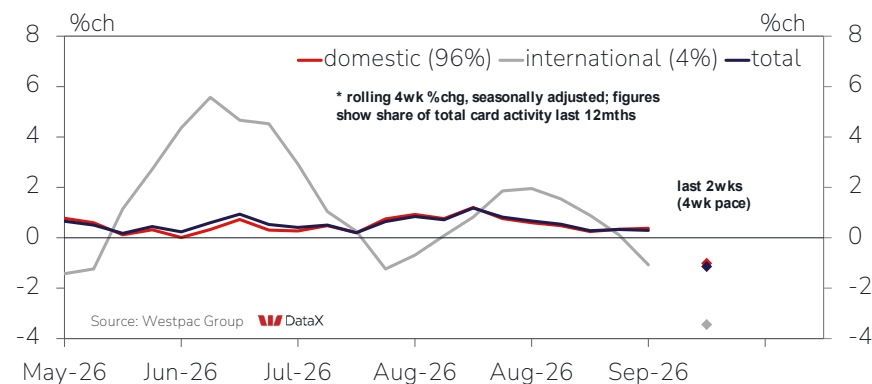


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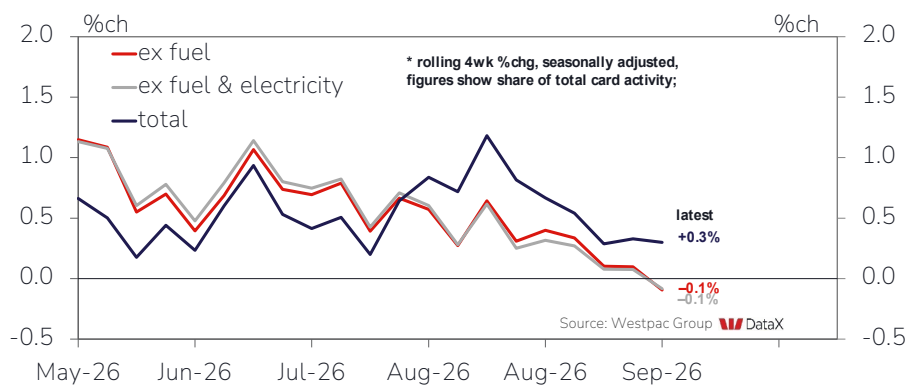
12. Card activity: online and in-store



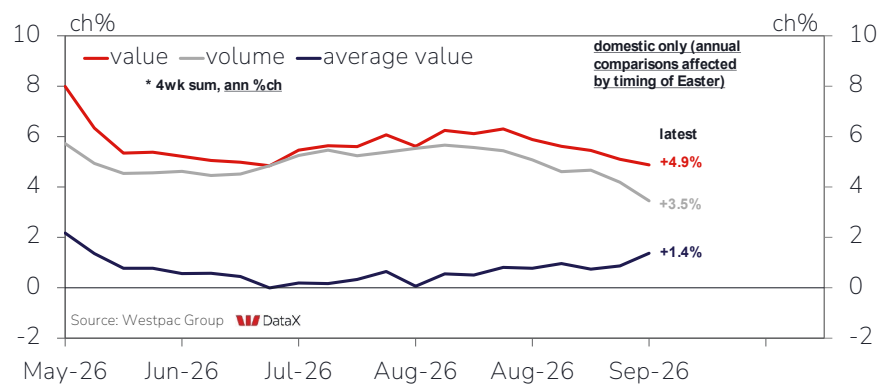
13. Card activity: food and non-food



14. Card activity: total, ex fuel and electricity



15. Card activity: value and volume



	2024		2025		2026		week ending:								
	Q3	Q4	Q1	Q2	Q3	Q4	Q1	Q2	Jun	Jul	Aug	5/9	12/9	19/9	26/9
Westpac–DataX Card Tracker Index	140.9	143.0	144.9	147.7	149.7	153.4	155.3	155.8	157.0	158.1	158.4	160.3	159.7	159.0	159.1
qtly%ch	0.4	1.5	1.3	1.9	1.3	2.5	1.2	0.3	0.3	1.1	1.3	1.7	1.8	1.8	1.7
qtly, ann%ch	3.9	5.3	4.0	5.2	6.2	7.2	7.2	5.5	5.5	5.8	6.1	6.0	5.9	5.8	5.6
By category															
– discretionary	142.9	145.6	146.2	149.3	151.3	155.1	155.9	157.1	159.2	160.4	159.9	163.1	161.8	160.6	159.7
– essential	137.7	138.6	141.4	143.7	145.8	148.5	151.3	151.6	151.6	152.7	153.6	155.3	155.4	155.5	156.6
services	147.4	150.3	152.8	156.6	159.6	163.1	164.9	165.4	167.9	169.2	169.2	171.8	170.2	170.1	170.2
– discretionary services	150.6	154.4	155.0	158.8	160.4	164.7	165.5	167.1	170.4	171.6	171.0	175.1	173.6	173.1	172.1
– essential services	142.8	144.5	149.6	153.5	158.5	160.9	164.1	163.1	164.2	165.6	166.6	167.0	165.3	165.7	167.6
goods	134.6	135.5	136.5	138.3	139.6	142.7	144.5	145.3	145.3	146.4	146.7	149.0	149.2	148.3	148.3
– discretionary goods	134.7	136.2	136.7	139.2	141.6	144.9	145.7	146.5	147.2	148.5	148.1	150.1	149.0	147.1	146.3
– essential goods	134.6	134.9	136.3	137.6	137.8	140.8	143.4	144.3	143.7	144.5	145.4	148.0	149.3	149.3	149.9
MHSI card index*	140.6	142.4	143.4	145.8	147.3	150.7	152.2	153.2	153.7	155.1	155.2	158.2	158.2	157.5	157.3
qtly%ch	0.4	1.3	0.6	1.7	1.0	2.3	1.0	0.7	0.7	1.0	0.8	1.4	1.5	1.6	1.6
qtly, ann%ch	3.0	4.6	2.7	4.1	4.8	5.8	6.2	5.1	5.1	5.2	5.4	5.5	5.5	5.5	5.3
retail card index*	141.0	142.7	143.4	146.1	147.9	151.3	152.1	153.8	154.6	155.6	155.2	156.6	156.2	154.5	154.2
qtly%ch	0.8	1.2	0.5	1.8	1.2	2.3	0.5	1.1	1.1	1.8	1.3	1.1	1.0	0.9	0.5
qtly, ann%ch	2.8	4.2	2.0	4.3	4.8	6.0	6.0	5.3	5.3	5.6	5.3	5.3	5.2	5.0	4.6
By state															
– NSW	136.6	138.6	139.4	142.4	144.4	148.2	148.4	149.1	149.8	151.2	151.0	155.6	155.4	154.7	154.4
– Vic	135.5	136.6	138.5	140.3	142.2	144.7	146.0	146.9	147.7	148.9	149.7	153.2	151.7	151.3	151.1
– Qld	150.7	153.0	155.1	159.4	161.9	167.7	169.0	170.1	171.8	174.1	172.6	175.4	175.6	175.4	174.8
– WA	151.1	153.7	156.7	159.4	163.0	167.9	170.8	171.6	173.9	175.7	176.7	181.5	180.3	179.9	178.6
– SA	147.7	150.1	152.0	154.5	157.3	160.2	162.2	162.9	163.6	165.0	166.3	168.4	167.8	166.5	166.9

All indexes based on the value of spending–related transactions, seasonally adjusted by Westpac, 2019 avg=100. See p9 for more details.

* composite based on transactions in categories in scope for ABS monthly spending indicator and ABS retail sales surveys respectively.

Sources: ABS, Westpac Group

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About the Westpac card data indicators

The indicators presented in this report are based on the millions of credit and debit card transactions processed every day. Transactions covering over ten million merchants are classified into over 700 categories. These are in turn grouped into higher level aggregates that provide a timely guide to wider economic trends.

The main focus of these indicators is consumer spending. Where possible, we have sought to exclude 'non spending' transactions such as: money transfers; tax payments; loan repayments; charitable donations; and superannuation contributions.

It should also be noted that these indicators will also be affected by shifts between card and non-card transactions. This was a significant factor during the COVID-19 pandemic – health concerns about the use of physical cash leading to significantly higher use of cards vs cash, particularly where contact-less transactions are available. Transaction flows also include reversals/refunds which were also a significant phenomenon during the onset of COVID, especially in areas such as travel.

All transaction data is compiled at a highly aggregated level so that individual customer or merchant data is never revealed.

Index construction

The key metrics used in this report are indexes of spending-related card activity where the base of 100 is average activity in 2019. As an example, if transaction flows are 5% above their average level in 2019, the index read for the period is 105. If flows in a subsequent period are 8% above the average level in 2019, the index read for this period is 108. Growth between the two periods can be calculated simply as the change between the two index reads, i.e. 2.9%.

All measures are adjusted for regular seasonality. Weekly estimates are generated using the US Bureau of Labor's MoveReg weekly seasonal adjustment program. Note that in some cases, high levels of volatility during the COVID period mean it is not possible to produce seasonally adjusted estimates for some historical periods.

Also, note that previous versions of this report used different approaches to seasonal adjustment and measurement more generally. This means Index reads are sometimes not directly comparable. See the 'About the Westpac card data indicators' sections from earlier reports to more detail.

Classifications

Note that the measures used for card data and in this report do not align completely with the those used in official ABS statistics, including the ABS household spending indicator, ABS retail trade survey and ABS estimate of consumer spending published in the national accounts. There are a range of differences including around both coverage and classification. As such, the card data should be treated as broadly indicative.

The transaction data is grouped into 26 categories that are then combined into four main as follows:

Discretionary goods: alcoholic beverages, tobacco, clothing & footwear, furnishings & household equipment, household appliances, vehicle-related, recreational & cultural goods, newspaper, books & stationery, and other personal effects.

Discretionary services: transport services (part), recreational & cultural services, gambling, catering services, accommodation services, other personal care, insurance & financial services, other services.

Essential goods: food & non alcoholic beverages, medical products, appliances & equipment, and operation of personal transport equipment.

Essential services: electricity, gas & other fuels, health services, transport services (part), communications and education.

The report also uses two additional classifications:

MHSI/Retail: based on the extent to which categories cover activity that is in scope for the ABS monthly household spending indicator and ABS retail trade survey.



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